

THE INHERITED HOME GUIDE

5 questions to ask before you sell *an inherited home.*

A short field guide for heirs in Greater Boston working through what to do with a property that has come into the family. The questions inside are the ones that change the tax bill, the family dynamic, and the path you actually take.

BEFORE YOU START

An inheritance is rarely *just a house*.

The first instinct when a home is inherited is usually one of two extremes. Sell it as fast as possible to be done with it, or hold onto it because letting go feels wrong. Both extremes get made before the math is done. Before probate is understood. Before the heirs have actually talked. Before the basis step-up has been mapped. The decisions made in the first few months of grief often turn out to be the most expensive ones.

The families I have walked through this calmly do not rush, and they do not freeze. They take a few weeks to understand what they have actually inherited, including the parts that are not on the deed. The tax position. The family dynamic. The condition of the building. The paths that fit. The wholesalers who will start appearing in the mailbox within days of the death certificate. These are the five questions I run every family through before any real decisions get made about the property.

How to use this guide

Read all five. Sit with the ones that surprise you. Bring the answers, or the questions you cannot answer, to whoever you trust to help you decide, including the estate attorney and your CPA. Or bring them to me on a 30 minute strategy session. There is no commitment to list.

01

QUESTION ONE · THE PROBATE

What stage is the estate in, *and what can the heirs legally do right now?*

WHY IT MATTERS

Most families do not know the answer to this question when they start making plans about the property. They assume probate is a formality and the house is already theirs to sell. Sometimes it is. Often it is not. A property can be in probate, out of probate, held in a trust, held jointly, held by multiple heirs with different views, or stuck waiting on paperwork that has not been filed yet. Each of those is a different timeline and a different set of legal moves available.

The question is not "when do we list." The question is what the estate is actually allowed to do today, and what would have to be true to move to the next step. Some sales can happen immediately. Some require probate to clear first. Some can happen with the right paperwork from a trustee or executor. Some are blocked by a co-heir who has a different view. The legal map comes first. Everything else follows.

WATCH OUT FOR

Anyone telling you to list before the estate attorney has confirmed what the executor or trustee can actually sign. The legal status sets the path.

02

QUESTION TWO · THE BASIS

Have you mapped the step-up in basis *and the tax implications of selling now versus later?*

WHY IT MATTERS

The biggest financial gift most heirs do not realize they have received is the step-up in basis. The property's tax basis usually resets to the value at the date of death, not what the original owner paid. A home bought in 1972 for one number and inherited at a much higher number has a basis that can dramatically reduce or eliminate the capital gains tax on a sale. Most heirs do not learn about this gift until after they have made decisions that quietly waste it.

The basis conversation belongs in the first few weeks, not the last few. A sale within the window where the step-up basis is documented and defensible can produce a meaningfully different after-tax number than a sale done casually with no records. If the family is considering holding the property and renting it, the step-up also resets the depreciation schedule. If one heir is considering buying out the others, the basis changes what that transaction actually costs. This is a CPA conversation, and it should happen alongside the agent conversation, not after it.

WATCH OUT FOR

Anyone who talks about price or timing without first asking what the estate's tax position looks like. A great sale price can quietly become a poor outcome if the tax setup gets mishandled.

03

QUESTION THREE • THE FAMILY

Are all of the heirs actually aligned *on selling, on price, and on timing?*

WHY IT MATTERS

Most families assume an alignment that does not actually exist. One sibling wants to sell now and move on. Another wants to wait. A third is quietly hoping to keep the house. A fourth has a strong opinion about the price that has nothing to do with the market. The decision gets made by whoever speaks first or pushes hardest, and the resentment that follows takes longer to clear than the sale does.

The conversation about the property is also a conversation about the family. Each heir's situation, financial position, and emotional connection to the home is different. A buyout, a delayed sale, a partial sale, or a short rental hold can all be the right answer for one family and the wrong answer for another. The decisions that hold up over time are the ones made with everyone in the room, not the ones made in side conversations. The house is the easy part. The alignment is the work.

WATCH OUT FOR

A decision made by one heir on behalf of the others. The cleanest sales are the ones where every heir has been heard before the listing decision is made.

04

QUESTION FOUR • THE CONDITION

What does this property realistically look like to a buyer, *and what is worth doing before it goes on the market?*

WHY IT MATTERS

Inherited Greater Boston homes are often older, often carry a generation of deferred maintenance, and almost always hold the kind of personal contents that take real time to sort through. The temptation is either to do nothing and sell as is, or to spend a lot of money trying to make the home look like a current renovation. Both extremes can be right, and both can be wrong, depending on the building, the location, and the buyer pool.

The honest comparison is what the home would net as is, against what it would net after a specific spend, factoring in the time, the carrying costs, and the family's tolerance for managing a project from grief. Sometimes a deep clean, a paint, and a clear-out unlock a real number. Sometimes the building is in a market where an investor will pay close to retail for it untouched. Sometimes a targeted spend on a few high-return items genuinely moves the price. The right answer is specific to the building, not a default.

WATCH OUT FOR

A long list of recommended improvements with no return attached to each. Every line on that list should have a number next to it.

Given probate, the tax position, the family, and the condition, *which exit actually fits?*

WHY IT MATTERS

Most inherited properties get sold on the open market by default, because that is what most agents recommend. For some properties that is the right call. For others, an off-market sale to a vetted investor, a sale to a neighbor or abutter, a buyout by one heir, or a short hold and rental can produce a meaningfully better outcome. The wholesaler letters that show up in the mailbox push hard on speed, but speed alone is rarely the strategy.

The right path is the one that fits the answers to the first four questions. A clean estate with aligned heirs and a turnkey home in a strong neighborhood is one conversation. A complicated estate with a building that needs work and heirs in different cities is a different conversation entirely. Each path has a different price, a different timeline, and a different level of family disruption. The right one gets decided after the first four questions have been answered, not before.

WATCH OUT FOR

Wholesalers who promise speed and certainty without ever asking what your actual goal is. Speed is one variable. The whole picture is the answer.

READY WHEN YOU ARE

Want to walk through this *for your family's situation?*

These are not the only questions worth running before selling an inherited home. They are the ones I have watched separate the families who land in a good place from the ones who carry regret about the property for years. If you want to walk through them on your specific situation with me, that is what a strategy session is for. No commitment to list.

Book my strategy session

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Krista Recker Properties

Strategy first. Decisions backed by data.